

In the end, a small—very small—window of opportunity did open. Spain briefly allowed the company exactly one voyage a year, subject to a share in its profits. Hope for something better was then partly sustained by the thought that sovereignty over Gibraltar might be traded for greater access to the Americas. The question of that sovereignty was, unfortunately, to remain in contention between Britain and Spain for another two and a half centuries and more.

It would be hard, in fact, to imagine a commercial project that was more questionable. But here, as in Paris, it was not a time for questions. Further issues of stock in return for further assumptions of the public debt were authorized and offered to the public, and, early in 1720, the whole public debt was assumed. Such were the presumed advantages of the enterprise. The legislation was facilitated by the endowment of gifts of the South Sea stock to key ministers of the government, and also by the happy circumstance that several directors of the enterprise sat in Parliament, with an excellent chance, in consequence, to make known therein the great prospects awaiting the company. The latter's directors were also generous in awarding stock to themselves.

In 1720, the British public, or rather that part susceptible to the thought of financial enrichment, responded powerfully to the seeming opportunity presented by the South Seas and yet more to the upward thrust of the stock and the desire to have a part in the gains. The war had enriched a small but significant sector of the British population. The landed and aristocratic classes, though contemptuous of those “in trade” or otherwise concerned with money-making, were also able to surmount their pride and come aboard—money often has that effect. The scenes in the Rue Quincampoix were now repeated in the streets and alleys of the City; the stock of the company, which had been at around £128 in January 1720, went to £330 in March, £550 in May, £890 in June, and to around £1,000 later in the summer. Not before in the kingdom, and perhaps not even in Paris or Holland, had so many so suddenly become so rich. As ever, the sight of some becoming so effortlessly affluent brought the rush to participate that further powered the upward thrust.

Nor was the South Sea Company the only opportunity. Its success spawned at least a hundred imitators and hitchhikers, all hoping to take